DESIGN IS INFRASTRUCTURE.

Design leadership for business growth and social progress across Africa: building the systems that make design commercially valuable, and the pathways that widen who gets to lead.

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BOLUTIFE AWAKAN

Founding Partner at Design Lever Inc.
Co-founder, Lilac Africa

bolutifeawakan.com

Bolutife Awakan is a Nigerian design leader and entrepreneur working where design, business and inclusive growth meet. She builds the leadership systems that help African organisations make design commercially valuable, and the learning pathways that help more African women participate in the technology economy.



Photographer - Abdulmatin Jimoh

Africa does not lack creative talent. The deeper gap is infrastructure: executive design leadership, commercial standards, evidence, career pathways and inclusive access to opportunity.

Through **Design Lever Inc.**, Bolutife helps organisations connect design to governance, operations and measurable business performance. Through **Lilac Africa**, she helps women gain the skills, support and networks required to enter and lead in technology.

Her books, mentoring and public speaking extend that work to creative professionals building sustainable careers. Together these efforts advance a single idea: transformation becomes credible when people can experience it in the systems, services and opportunities around them.

TALENT ALONE IS NOT AN ECONOMY.

At a glance:

10yrs

Over a decade across brand, product, creative and executive design leadership

1500

Women trained through Lilac Africa since 2024

04

Connected capabilities inside Design Lever: fractional leadership, academy, network, research

02

Published resources on personal branding and sustainable creative practice

Selected organisations & partners

traction

Interswitch

terragon

rise

MAVIN RECORDS

Building design leadership infrastructure for African businesses

Design Lever Inc. ·

Founding Partner · 2026–present

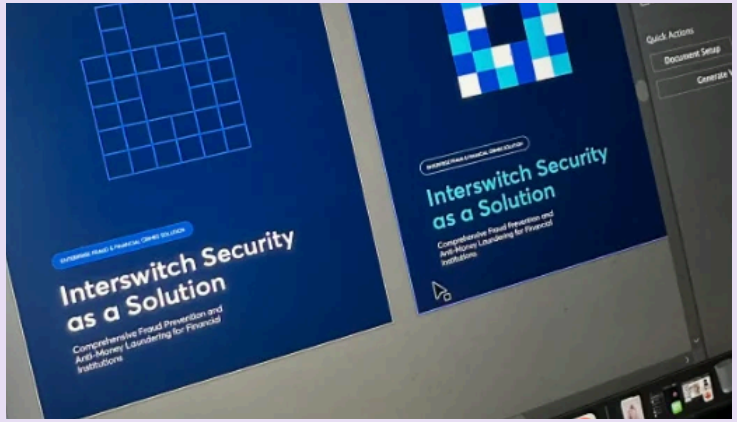
Design Lever helps growth-stage African companies turn design from a fragmented service into an accountable business capability: fractional design leadership, leadership development, a vetted network of senior practitioners, and research into the commercial contribution of design across Africa.

Her focus includes team structure, governance, standards, ways of working, commercial measurement and the executive integration of product, brand, marketing, communications, research and design operations.

The Design Lever model

01	**Fractional leadership firm**	Embedded executive design leadership that aligns brand, product and business priorities, without the cost of a permanent senior hire.
02	**Academy**	Practical learning & development that helps design managers and directors lead teams, influence executives and connect design decisions to business outcomes.
03	**Fractional Talent Network**	A vetted network of senior African design leaders matched to organizations needing specialist expertise, interim leadership or additional capacity.
04	**Research & community**	Research, practical resources and peer learning that demonstrate design's commercial value and strengthen Africa's design leadership ecosystem.

Selected design work



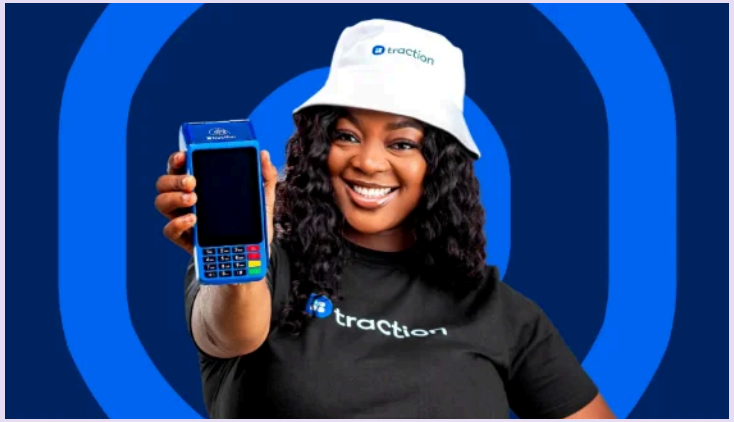
Organizational transformation, One source of truth, 30% faster.

Interswitch group · Strategy & content design · 2025

Challenge: Fragmented product stories across business lines slowed marketing delivery.

Leadership decision: Replaced department-owned versions with one governed content system, prioritizing consistency and speed over local flexibility, with clear ownership for version updates.

Result: Cut content turnaround time by at least 30% and made approved information easier to find.



A refreshed brand supporting a $6M raise.

Traction · Creative, product & brand management · 2023

Challenge: The existing logo created infringement risk of millions of dollars and no longer supported the company's ambitions.

Leadership decision: Secured the budget for a company-wide refresh, keeping it simple and familiar to retain some brand equity. Customer feedback guided the rollout.

Result: Strengthened customer and investor confidence and contributed to a $6 million raise six months later.



80% increase recorded in merchandise sales.

Make Music Lagos · Lead Designer / Planning Contributor · 2022

Challenge: A distinctive cultural identity that could build audience connection and extend into a viable merchandise system.

Leadership decision: Created a bold, identity built around vibrant colour, energy and cultural expression that could scale across multiple uses and cities.

Result: The festival recorded its highest merchandise sales to date.

Expanding pathways for African women in technology through Lilac





Photographer - Jeffrey Oba

Lilac Africa · Co-founder · 2024–present

Lilac Africa is an education and community platform helping African women develop technology skills, professional confidence and access to opportunity. Its model combines practical training with gender-responsive support, scholarships, mentorship and a collaborative community.

1500+

Women trained

100+

Fully funded places in a four-month nanodegree

₦10M

Grant after reaching the finals of Standard Chartered Women in Tech, Cohort 5











Making creative careers more sustainable

Bolutife translates business knowledge into practical tools for African creatives, addressing two recurring barriers: building an authentic and commercially credible personal brand, and pricing creative work in a way that protects both value and livelihood.



Worth the Work

A costing and pricing framework helping African freelancers distinguish sustainable revenue from work that quietly erodes time and margin.

Mentorship. Bolutife mentors hundreds of designers and creative professionals across 15 countries through ADPList and other community platforms. Her public teaching focuses on design leadership, brand strategy, the business value of design and sustainable creative practice.

Design as institutional infrastructure

How leadership, governance, standards and measurement turn design into an accountable organisational capability.

Inclusive digital participation

How education, community and gender-responsive support create stronger pathways for African women into technology and leadership.

Africa’s creative economy

How fair pricing, business literacy, executive design leadership and professional standards help creative talent generate greater economic value.

Trust by design

How organisations make transformation tangible through clearer services, more coherent experiences and systems built around human needs.

Speaking topics

01	**Design is infrastructure: what African organisations need beyond talent**	Africa's creative workforce is growing, but talent alone cannot produce a mature design economy. The leadership, standards, research and commercial accountability required to make design valuable at institutional scale.
02	**From creative output to economic value**	Why organisations underuse design, what executive design leadership changes, and how teams connect design decisions to revenue, trust, adoption and long-term capability.
03	**Designing pathways for women to lead in technology**	Lessons from building Lilac Africa: combining practical education, scholarships, community and gender-responsive support to move women from access to participation and leadership.
04	**Worth the work: sustainable creative careers in emerging markets**	A practical framework for costing, pricing and protecting creative value, so talent becomes a durable livelihood rather than a cycle of busy but unprofitable work.
05	**Trust by design: making transformation visible and usable**	How leaders translate ambitious transformation agendas into services, systems and experiences that people can understand, use and believe in.

Keynote · panel · workshop

Selected experience

Founder & Managing partner — Design Lever Inc.

Co-founder — Lilac Africa · 2024–present

Chief Design Officer — Neo Health

Creative Director — Capex Funds

Senior design & brand roles — Interswitch Group, Traction Apps, Terragon Group

Lead Designer / Planning Contributor
Make Music Lagos

Education, recognition & service

Exponential Design Leader (DLX)
Future London Academy Executive Programme for Design Leaders; global cohort of 30

MBA — Rome Business School

Brand Designer of the Year
No Code Tech Awards, 2023

Mentor — ADPList

Advisory board
TRLH · Paragone Signature & Associates



Photographer - John Phillips (Getty Images)

Press assets

High-resolution portraits →

Logos & brand marks →

Current CV →

Biographies

35-word introduction

Bolutife Awakan is a Nigerian design leader, entrepreneur and author building design leadership infrastructure for African businesses and inclusive pathways for women into technology through Design Lever Inc. and Lilac Africa.

90-word speaker biography

Bolutife Awakan is a Nigerian design leader, entrepreneur and author working at the intersection of design, business and inclusive growth. As Founding Partner of Design Lever Inc., she helps African organisations build the leadership, systems and standards that turn design into business value. She also co-founded Lilac Africa, an education and community platform expanding pathways for women into technology. Across nearly a decade, her career has spanned brand, product, creative and executive design leadership. She is the author of *SIGNATURE* and *Worth the Work* and holds an MBA from Rome Business School.

180-word media biography

Bolutife Awakan is a Nigerian design leader, entrepreneur and author whose work connects organisational growth with wider access to opportunity. As Founding Partner of Design Lever Inc., she is helping build the leadership infrastructure African businesses need to make design commercially valuable: executive accountability, stronger operating systems, professional standards, leadership development, networks and evidence.

She also co-founded Lilac Africa, an education and community platform that supports African women entering technology through practical training, scholarships, mentorship and gender-responsive community. Her broader contribution to the creative economy includes mentoring designers and publishing practical resources on personal branding and sustainable pricing.

Across nearly a decade, Bolutife has worked across brand, product, creative and executive design leadership in fintech, health technology and other growth sectors, including roles connected with Interswitch Group, Traction Apps, Terragon Group, Capex Funds and Neo Health. She is the author of *SIGNATURE: The Journey to Your Authentic Brand* and *Worth the Work*. Bolutife holds an MBA from Rome Business School and is an Exponential Design Leader (DLX), awarded through Future London Academy's Executive Programme for Design Leaders.

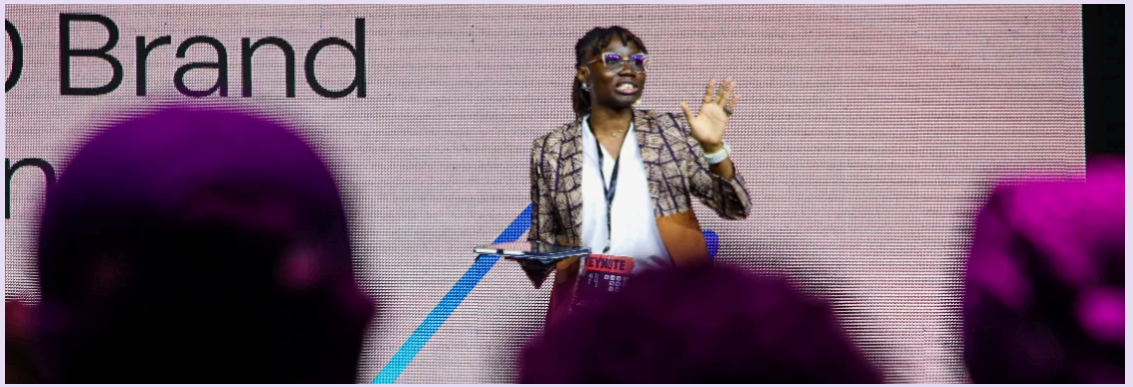
Media & features



Design Spinoff

The role of design leadership in driving growth

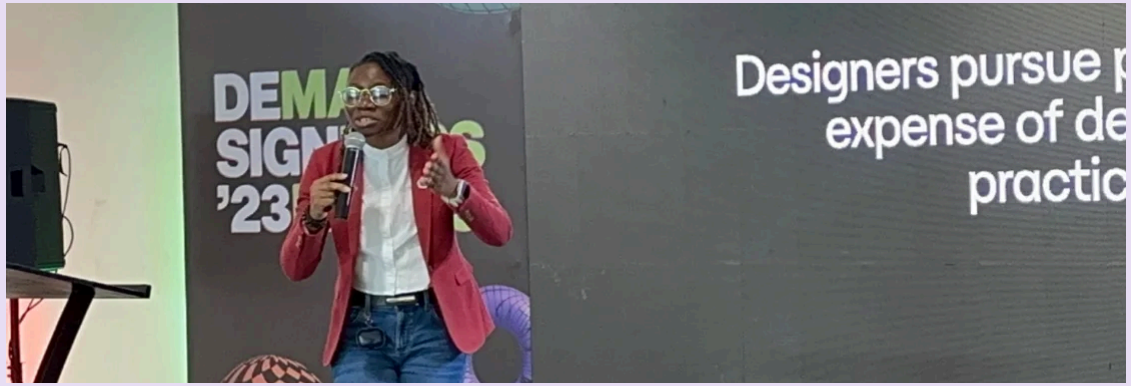
Panel · 2024



Untitled Designers' Conference

Branding with authenticity admist 'content' noise

Keynote · 2024



Design Matters

Creativity for social change

Speaker · 2023



Podcast

Understanding Branding

Interview · 2024

LET’S TALK SPEAKING, MEDIA AND PARTNERSHIPS.

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